

STEWARDSHIP SEASON

Watch your mailboxes for a stewardship mailing soon. Pledge forms can also be picked up in the Welcome Center or filled out online. See page 9 for more information.



OCTOBER 2026 EVENTS

Oct 5

Trustees, 7:00 pm

Oct 6

Stewards, 6:30 pm

Oct 7

Youth Club begins

Oct 12

Office closed for holiday

Oct 17

Fall, Fellowship, Fun
(senior luncheon), 11:00 am

Oct 19

Official Board, 7:00 pm

Oct 24

Adult Retreat at Onanda, 9:30 am



FROM THE PASTOR

Moving into Unfinished Space



As some of you know I've been finishing our basement for the past three years. I've had to learn along the way, beginning with the studs, then the electrical work, the walls, the ceiling, the flooring. It's still not done.

Even though our basement is not complete, we've had guests come to visit. They've stayed in this unfinished space. At first sleeping on air mattresses, but slowly and surely, as rooms have come together, we now have proper bedding, flooring, furniture, in some of the space.

In October we'll continue our study through the book of Zechariah. God is speaking into the unfinished project of the temple. And the people are sometimes engaged and attentive to all that He's doing. Other times they are rejecting Him and turning away. Yet in the middle of it all God is speaking to them about what He's going to do one day. This image of an unfinished project also relates to people. Their obedience and faithfulness come and go. It is certainly not complete.

The good news is that God doesn't wait for everything to be in order. He tells them that He's going to show up in the middle of their waffling. And instead

continues Page 2

INSIDE:

Page 5: Missionary Spotlight - Sally Gates

Page 11: Are You Ready for Youth Club?

Page 13: Adult Retreat

Page 15: The Fellowship Community, article 3

FROM THE PASTOR

Moving into Unfinished Space

continued from Page 1

of waiting on them to get everything together, He steps in and completes the work for them.

Each week this month we will move

through the heart of Zechariah. Each week adds a layer of a guest moving into unfinished space. On October 4 God tells His people He's not just visiting. He's coming to stay. The next Sunday, October 11, we see God stepping in to transform the space. He's not just a guest. He's active in doing the work of renovation. On October 18, the temple

foundation is still untouched. God reminds us that the progress will happen through His Spirit alone, not through our effort. And on October 25, we learn that it's really not about building the structure. It's about the one who's moving in. Are we in relationship with Him? Do we know Him?

God doesn't wait for us to be finished. God doesn't wait for us to get our lives in order. He comes in the midst of construction, in the midst of exposed ceilings and unfinished drywall work. He moves in and begins to transform us.

Join us this month as we explore these passages together.

Wade



WORSHIP SCHEDULE

October 04 - Coming to Stay (Zechariah 2)

Additional Readings: Psalm 84:1-4, Ephesians 2:19-22

October 11 - A New Beginning (Zechariah 3)

Additional Readings: Psalm 51:7-12, Ephesians 4:20-5:2

October 18 - A Work in Progress (Zechariah 4-6)

Additional Readings: Psalm 104:27-30, Philippians 1:3-6

October 25 - Is Your Heart In It? (Zechariah 7-8)

Additional Readings: Psalm 51:15-17, Mark 7:5-8

"The seed will grow well, the vine will yield its fruit, the ground will produce its crops, and the heavens will drop their dew. I will give all these things as an inheritance to the remnant of this people. As you have been an object of cursing among the nations, O Judah and Isreal, so I will save you, and you will be a blessing. Do not be afraid, but let your hands be strong."

- Zechariah 8:12-13



Bell Choir!

If you eagerly anticipate the United Church Bell Choir performances, you'll want to put October 25th on your calendar!

World Mission Offering

On **Sunday October 4** our church will be taking **World Mission Offering**. This special offering is divided between **American Baptist World Mission Offering** and **The Presbyterian Disaster Assistance Program**.

The American Baptist International Mission organization supports international missionaries and short term volunteers in over 70 countries. We can respond to the needs around the world by your gift to help support global servants with training and pastoral care, helping to address crises when they arise, and much more.

The Presbyterian Disaster Assistance program is an emergency and refugee program of the Presbyterian Church (USA) which provides immediate and long-term support to communities affected by natural and human-caused disasters. Currently some of the areas being helped are Venezuela due to earthquakes, central Indiana due to severe flooding, and Nepal where we are helping to provide medical kits, food items, shelter, and more and will continue support through the long-term recovery phase.

God is at work rebuilding, restoring, and renewing, and our gifts to this offering are one of the best ways that we can support this work. Thank you for giving as generously as you are able.

MISSIONS



Family Promise Gift Cards

Family Promise of Ontario County (FPOC) helps families facing or experiencing **homelessness** by supporting them with a stable place to live while learning skills on budgeting income, managing a family and household, finding employment, and more to provide the needed stability to get out of poverty. The new FPOC static site on N. Main is active and open! God knows and cares! And so do we!

During **October**, our church family would like to help FPOC by **donating \$25, \$50, or \$100 grocery and/or fuel gift cards, or by writing a check to Family Promise**. Families purchase their own groceries, make their own meals, and fuel their own cars, if they have them. Please consider chipping in! Gift cards may be placed in the offering plate or left with Carolyn during office hours. Questions? Please see Cathy or Mary Lou. Please add your prayers to this and Thank You for your consideration!
- The Mission Collection Team



Beaver Camp Fundraising Dinner

November 7, 2026 @ 5:30 pm
The United Church Dining Room

An opportunity to support and learn about the place that has changed the lives and faith of many in our congregation.

Tickets are complimentary, and we graciously ask guests to make a donation to help support the event and its mission. Your generosity is appreciated.
See Bob or Brenda Cunningham for tickets.



MISSIONS

2027 Inter-generational Mission Trip

The 2027 trip will once again be going to **Black Mountain, NC**. While there is not as much need for Hurricane Helene relief work, our church has developed a relationship with the **Valley Hope Foundation (valleyhopefoundation.org)** that we are eager to continue! The work with them will continue to be light construction and helping with the food sorting/distribution that they provide to the several counties in that area.

We are also hoping to work with **Black Mountain Home for children (BMH) (blackmountainhome.org)**. This organization works with children displaced from their families.

When children are in need of out-of-home placement, BMH can meet those needs through all the stages and phases of their growing up years. From infants born prematurely or with addictions to young adults working toward an educational or career goal, the ministry provides a safe, supportive home for youth of all ages and stages.

Programs include:

- *Community-based foster care (foster families needed).*
- *Campus-based cottage care on our campuses in Black*

Mountain and Pisgah Forest, NC.

• *Independent Living Program for older youth continuing their education beyond high school or working toward a career goal through our Apprenticeship Program.*

• *Lifelong Living for those with developmental disabilities who will need support as they move into adulthood.*

The work with this organization will be determined as we get closer.

The mission trip will once again be the week of Spring Break so that families are able to participate, **March 20 – March 26**. The cost for the trip is low and scholarships are available. There will be an **informational meeting on Sunday, Oct.11 at 12:00 in the Fellowship room.**

Please contact Sonya B. (sonya.brooks99@yahoo.com) with any questions or if you are interested but cannot make the meeting.



Mexico Mission Trip 2027

A Mexico 2027 Mission Team has formed and four of us have just returned from training at **Clean Water U**. Living Waters for the World (LWW) knows us as the “NY Living Waters for the World Team” because for the last several years we have combined volunteers from the United Church, Newark Rotary, and other New Yorkers who have trained at Clean Water U. An itinerary each year always includes time with mission partners in the water communities of Cedralito, Limones, and Tabi ... sharing a fellowship meal together, engaging in activities, and assessing the sustainability of the water plant. We now also include time with Pastor Leo, his wife Ángela, and the congregation at Iglesia Emmanuel in Bacalar, the former mission partner of the United Church back in the days of the Presbytery of Geneva mission trips. Some of that is back history. Every trip now offers new opportunities, creative relationships, and engaging community activities. In 2027 we’ll be bringing Nancy B-P’s “stampin’ up” card making activity to the women in Bacalar. In Tabi we’ll be training young adults to carry out the health and spiritual activities connected with the water plant. Activities in Cedralito and Limones are still being planned. We hope that those not traveling with us may want to support us as we fundraise and gather supplies. Some fundraisers are happening now with friends and family and of course another **Mexican Night Dinner** is coming next March for church members and the Canandaigua community. There’s an open invitation to travel with us from **March 14-24, 2027** ... especially for a Spanish speaker. Contact Linda Werts.



Foodlink “Pop-Up Food Pantry”

will welcome United Church volunteers on **Monday, October 19th from 9:00-11:00am** at the Town of Canandaigua Highway Barn, 5440 Route 5 & 20. Help is needed to package food items coming off the Foodlink truck and to load them into vehicles as recipients drive through the barn. This worthy program offers emergency food relief to our neighbors in need and an opportunity for United Church volunteers to partner together with others in “hands-on” mission.



Missionary Visit

Carlos Bonilla and Mayra Giovanetti are a missionary couple that our church supports. They have been used by God in discipleship in churches and with ethnic groups in Colombia through UNIBAUTISTA. This includes the Wayuu in The Guajira-Northern Region. Their ministry also includes Chile, Spain, Nicaragua, and the wider regional context of Iberoamerica and the Caribbean. The BGs have served since 2000 through International Ministries, registered as the American Baptist Foreign Mission Society.



Carlos and Mayra recently returned from 9 weeks of ministry in Spain between April and July, impacting 17 churches with their discipleship encounter materials. Upon return, they’ve been on their annual US/PR assignment that continues until October 31st. The BGs regularly write Acts and Love in Action-BGs Et Al. The BGs are regional consultants for discipleship that “love intentionally (Rom. 12:15) while correctly explaining the word of truth (2 Tim. 2.15), knowing God provides the growth (1 Cor. 3.6-9)”.

Mayra will be giving a presentation on October 10th from 11:00 AM–2:00 PM at Webbs Crossing Bible Church in Hornell. A light lunch will be served prior to the presentation. Cathy B. (cbush1126@frontier.com) and Sonya B. (sonya.brooks99@yahoo.com) will be attending and are happy to carpool with anyone interested in going. **Please let one of us know by October 7th** (even if you don’t want to carpool) so that we can RSVP to the Hornell church.

Missionary Spotlight - Sally Gates

We all play a role in supporting our missionaries, whether that means financially, through prayer, or even one on one contact with them. But have you ever wondered what exactly this support allows them to do in the world around them? Sally Gates is one of the missionaries our church helps support, and she and her husband, Reece, are located in Brighton, England. Sally enjoys spending time on the coast paddle boarding, exploring the local coffee shop culture, volunteering at the local foodbank, and hiking. She works through Greater European Missions, and oversees HR and applications, onboarding and offboarding, receiving missionaries into the UK and sending them abroad, policies, visas, safeguarding, partnerships and contracts, and much more! She recently moved from position of Chief Operating Officer to the Chief of Staff position, where she will be leading the executive team alongside their CEO and having a hand in operations, ministry, and mobilization. Sally is originally from Indiana, and moved to Central Europe to lead a team in Ljubljana, Slovenia, doing ministry with university students after she graduated. Ten years later, she moved to serve in the UK with GEM, and became a part of a local CrossFit-style gym as a platform for evangelism. Sally works mostly in the behind the scenes missions, supporting and supplying missionaries with what they need to carry out their commission in the UK. If she were to impart her greatest wisdom, it would be this, “Thank the people doing the unseen work - you don’t realise how vital they are until they’re not there”. If this is your first time hearing about Sally Gates, it is not too late to do your part to support her or our other missionaries. Prayers are a great way to do this, and if you feel the Lord calling you to do more, feel free to reach out to a staff member or the missions committee to find out ways you can be involved in the lives of our missionaries.



~ written by Summer C. (her missionary liaison)

MISSIONS



CHURCH LIFE EVENTS



Game Night

Looking for something fun to do? Join us for a Game Night on **Saturday, October 10, from 6:30-8:30 pm**. This family friendly event offers an opportunity for church members of all ages to come together and enjoy a variety of board games, card games, and friendly competition. Whether you're a seasoned game master or just looking to have fun, there's something for everyone. **Snacks and refreshments will be available** to enjoy as you engage in lighthearted fun and connect with others in the church community. Bring your friends, family, or come solo -- game night is a great way to meet new people and build lasting relationships. We look forward to seeing you there!

Stampin' Up

October 3rd from 10:00-noon in the Dining Room (different week and location than normal!)

Come join us to create some cards. No experience is needed. Cost is \$20 for 4 cards and envelopes. Please bring a tape runner or glue. I will have everything else needed. Please let me know if you are coming by the Monday prior.

Email Nancy Burt-Preece: nancyburtprece@gmail.com



Caregiver Coffee Klatch

The Caregiver Coffee Klatch meets **every 1st and 3rd Monday from 10:30-11:30** in the fellowship room. This group is open to any caregiver from our church family or the community. Anyone may join us at any time. Flyers are available in the Gathering Area. Feel free to share a flyer with anyone you know who might find a time of rest, gentle conversation, and laughter a source of encouragement. Questions: Contact Kory at korymassey3@gmail.com



FAMILY NEWS

Celebrating

We are delighted to celebrate the birth of **Clara Ann Parsons** on August 21st. Her parents are **Dan and Lexi Parsons**. Her grandparents are **Ric and Ellen Parsons**. Please keep the family in your prayers during this special time.

We lovingly welcome the birth of **Laena Mary Storie** on August 26th. Her parents are **Oliver and Emma (Arthur) Storie**. Her grandparents are **John and Tracy Arthur**. Please keep the family in your prayers during this special time.

Announcing the birth of **Elijah Matthew Ripoli** on September 15th. His parents are **Margaret and Nate Ripoli**. He is joyfully welcomed by his siblings, Isaac, Peter, and Elinor. His grandparents are **Melissa and Tom Wormer**. May God bless Elijah with a life filled with faith, love, and joy, and may He grant the entire Ripoli family abundant grace as they celebrate this precious new addition!

We joyfully celebrate the birth of **Anna Elaine Marcheselli** on September 5th in Michigan. Her parents are **Macy and Ed Marcheselli**. Her grandparents are **Jenny and Jeb Baxter**. Please keep the family in your prayers during this special time.

Remembrance

Our prayers and sympathy are with **Dawn Doebler** for the loss of her daughter, **Alyssa Dinh**, on September 1st. Please keep the Doebler family in your prayers during this difficult time.

Our prayers and sympathy are with **Karen VanBlargan**, whose husband, **Jon VanBlargan**, passed away on September 20th. Please keep the family in your prayers during this difficult time.

A Reminder: Prayer Support Is Available

Following the 11:00 a.m. worship service, trained Care Ministers and Stewards are available in the Narthex to listen, offer encouragement, and pray for you in a quiet and confidential setting.

Whether you are carrying a concern, seeking guidance, celebrating good news, or simply needing support, they would be honored to spend a few moments in prayer with you.



Loose offering collection for October

Throughout October, November, and December, we make the Stewards Assistance Fund a special focus of our giving. Any loose offering received on the first Sunday of each month is also directed to the fund. These gifts provide confidential support to those who are part of our church family and facing unexpected needs, allowing us to share Christ's love in practical ways. Thank you for your generosity!



Fall Fellowship & Fun

Saturday, October 17, from 11:00 a.m. to 1:00 p.m.

Hosted by our Stewards for all our friends ages 85 and older

Join us for a special fall gathering beginning with worship and Communion led by Pastor Wade. Afterward, the Stewards will serve lunch, followed by a sing-along of favorite oldies with Dan on guitar, Becky on piano, and Sharyn singing. We'll also enjoy lighthearted activities and plenty of time to visit with friends.

To RSVP, contact Christy at 765-717-5229 or christy.allen@uccdga.org

We look forward to sharing this wonderful fall day with you!

Would you join our Card Team to Send Cards of Care?

We could use a few more volunteers for our Care Ministry Card Team. When someone in our church family is having surgery, dealing with an illness, grieving a loss, or celebrating something joyful like a new baby, our team makes sure they receive a card letting them know we care.

Volunteers take turns sending cards, so it's a simple way to help that doesn't require a large time commitment. A few handwritten words can mean so much to someone who needs encouragement, or someone who would love to have us share in their joy. (You do not have to make the cards/notes).

Sue V. coordinates the Card Team and would be glad to tell you more. You may also contact Christy, Director of Care Ministry, at 765-717-5229 or christy.allen@uccdga.org or Sue at 585-739-8615 or seavad@rochester.rr.com



HISTORY & ARCHIVES



From Our History

The United Church **Communion Flagon (pitcher), chalice and plate** are treasures from the past. They were manufactured by the Meriden Britannia Company in Connecticut during the late 19th century. The flagon features a double wall insulation and false bottom with weep holes. The ornament on the top of the lid is not original. Meriden used glass or ceramic knobs so at some point over the years, it has been replaced. It is silver plated with an inscription: *From, Mrs. George Hills, to the First Presbyterian Church, Canandaigua, NY, May 15, 1871.*

So who was Mrs. George Hills? Per the original minutes, regarding the initial organization of the First Presbyterian Church it states: “With the view of organising the First

Presbyterian Church, the following persons obtained letters of dismission. There is a list and Mr. George Hills and Mrs. Rhoda Hills (wife) are on it. A letter of dismission is a letter of transfer indicating that the member is in good standing at the current church (which was the Congregational Church) and should be welcomed into the new church.

Per the Churches of Canandaigua History of Canandaigua, published in 1893, (pages 229-235) I did discover that George Hills was one of the first Deacons of the First Presbyterian Church along with Daniel Alverson. Per the 1870 census, George was a wealthy man.

Rhoda Hills died February 3, 1871 at age 79. George remarried June 13, 1872 to Mrs. Katherine A. Moore of Canandaigua. (The local newspaper, The Ontario Repository and Messenger published the announcement of the marriage.)

George died February 21, 1886 at the age of 85.

Per his will George was survived by his second wife, Katherine A. Moor Hills, James Hills, his eldest son born 1826 in England, agriculturist and land builder; William Hills, born 1829 in England; Henry Hills, born 1832 in NY, prominent local bricklayer and building contractor in Canandaigua and he acted as the primary executor of the will; Mary Hills born 1835 in NY.

George is buried in the West Avenue Cemetery, Canandaigua, with Rhoda (which was the custom of the day).

~ written by Sharyn Canham

Interested in History?

Did the above story intrigue you and make you want to dig through other pieces of our 150+ years of Presbyterian, Baptist, and United history? Do you enjoy organizing, scanning, and displaying recent (and not-so-recent) photos, documents, and other items? Do you have a story about the United Church from “days gone by” that you’d like to share? Let a staff member know and we can put your gifts of time to use!



TREASURER'S REPORT

Financial Report through August 31st.

During the first seven months of the year, donations and pledges received were \$13,221.45 less than budgeted and \$8,957.68 less than the same period in 2025. Total net loss for this period was \$25,026.59. Our budget for 2026 predicted that we would have a deficit of \$23,621.31, so we have lost an additional \$1,405.28 so far.

We have had two months so far this year where we have not even been able to cover all of the costs for the staff let alone any other expenses that we incur on a regular basis. The staff are doing all that they can to cut back on costs. Ultimately, our financial problems are not due to spending more than expected; they are due to a large decrease in pledges and donations that we were unable to predict. **Please prayerfully consider contributing more to help keep our programs going.**

We will begin the budgeting process for 2027 very soon and anticipate having less money to allocate to programs. For this reason, **we are not inviting budget requests for 2027.** At some point this fall, we will contact each program/team/committee and let you know how much we anticipate being able to allocate to you. All groups will be receiving less than they have in the past.

The Finance Committee will hold an informational meeting with regards to the finances on Sunday Oct 18th. Please watch for more information in the next few weeks.

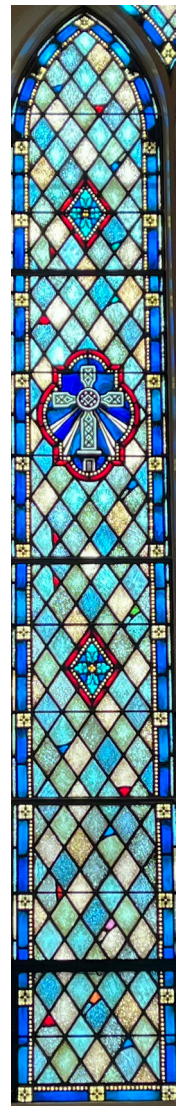


A Note from Your Financial Secretary

If you have not yet received your Stewardship letter and pledge forms in the mail, they should be arriving soon. The Finance Committee has been working hard to make sure you have the information you need. We invite you to stay after the worship service on October 18th for a few minutes (right in the sanctuary) for a brief informational session and Q&A about the current financial situation.

If possible, we would like to have pledges submitted by the end of October. You can mail them back, put them in the offering plate on Sunday or fill them out digitally by following the link on our website or scanning the QR code below.

Watch the weekly bulletins to track our pledging progress.
(I'm sure I'll come up with a clever visual "thermometer" ... a turkey trot?
a stained glass window? Keep watching to find out!)



CHILDREN'S & FAMILY MINISTRY



Sunday school

Our Sunday school year is off to a great start! Children ages 3-years-old through High School are welcome to join their age/grade based class on *any* Sunday. We also offer classes for adults; please see the adult ministry information for more details. Nursery care is offered for infants and toddlers so that everyone can participate in the Sunday school hour. When it works for your family's schedule, we hope you will join us at 9:45am! We have many dedicated volunteers helping each week with Sunday school. Below is a list of our 2026-2027 volunteers. Please keep this ministry in your prayers.

Our Sunday Morning Team 2026-2027

Nursery Coordinator: Louise V.

Nursery during Sunday School (infants — 2-years-old): Megan F. and Claire S.

Music (3-year-olds – 5th grade): Jen C., Stephanie C., Amelia C., and Anna Z.

Children's Time (K-2nd during 11am Worship): Ric and Ellen P.

Learning to Worship/Understanding your Faith (3rd-5th grade): Nancy A. and Lauren S.

Adult Sunday school: Nancy A., Levi A., Pastor Wade Allen, Gail B., Bob and Brenda C., Steve S.

Children's Sunday school classes:

3 & 4 year olds: Jen C. and Jinilee H., **Prayer Partner:** Robin P.

K, 1st and 2nd grade: Jen E. and Julie Z.; **Prayer Partner:** Roberta O.

3rd, 4th & 5th grade: Ryan M. and Mack W.; **Prayer Partner:** Sharon E.

MS (6th - 8th grade): Sandi D. and Blair P.; **Prayer Partner:** Sue V.

HS (9th - 12th grade): Ray M. and Lauren S.; **Prayer Partner:** Gail B.

Mark your Calendar...

*Sunday, October 11 –
Intergenerational, missions-focused
Sunday school at 9:45am in the
downstairs dining room.*

**“Why do you just write people's last initials instead of their whole name?
It's so confusing!”**

*The quick answer to this is online privacy concerns. Because our newsletter and bulletins are posted on our website, it is safer for our folks to **not** have their entire name listed. You can always contact the church office or any staff member if you have questions or need verification of who someone is.*



Youth Club

What is LOGOS?

LOGOS is a Christian ministry that works in partnership with local church leaders to build young disciples of Jesus Christ. We have been blessed to have Youth Club (LOGOS) at our church for **60 years!!!** At The United Church, we have two LOGOS programs:

Youth Club for 2nd - 8th grade, Wednesdays after school until 6:30pm, October - April

The Cause for 9th-12th grade students, Sundays, 5:00-7:30pm, mid-September - mid-May

Please join us during either service on October 4 for our LOGOS dedication when we come before the Lord to ask His guidance and blessings upon our LOGOS students and workers for this coming year.

Needed: Pizza Servers and Kitchen "Cleaner Uppers"

For the first Youth Club, **October 7**, from 5:15-6:15ish, **2 pizza servers** are needed in the fellowship room to serve

parents stopping by for a quick bite before our opening program. AND from 5:30-6:30ish **5 to work clean up** in the downstairs dining room kitchen after our pizza dinner (we'll use paper products this night), so YC students, workers and parents can all be part of our opening program in the sanctuary. **Please sign up on Deb's door. Thank you!**

Parents of Youth Club Students ~ Please plan to join us by 6pm on the first day of Youth Club (Oct. 7) for our opening Youth Club. Beginning at 5:40pm, you can grab a quick slice of pizza in the fellowship room, then proceed to the sanctuary to sit with your child by 6pm. Our time should conclude at 6:30. We look forward to seeing you there!



Youth Club Mission Project: Christmas Stockings for NYC. Christmas, already???? Well, it's almost time for our Youth Club mission project of making, filling and sending Christmas stockings to Metro Ministries in NYC in time for their special Christmas parties for inner-city children. Many inner-city children do not know what it's like to receive something handmade with love and care. These filled stockings show we care....because Christ cares for them, we care. **Would you be willing to provide stocking stuffers for this project?**

Items must be new, small and able to fit into a 5"x9" stocking. Items needed: toy cars, yo-yos, small games, bouncy balls, gum, socks, hard candy, hair accessories, jump ropes, coin purses, jewelry, watches, trading cards, pencils/pencil sharpeners, gloves, hats, small stuffed animals or dolls, etc!!! Note: Coloring books and most small puzzles are too large for these stockings. Please no toy weapons or violent action figures.

Thank you!!

Please bring your donations to Deb's office. Items need to be donated **by November 1**. Thank you!!

Important dates...

Sunday, October 4 - During both services: Dedicate LOGOS volunteers
Wednesday, October 7 - Youth Club begins! (Register online by Sept 30th)

Mark's Pastoral Reflection

An encouraging interaction with the next generation...

Mid-September, I was reading a theology book for school at a local coffee shop. A man in his 20's sat next to me, noticed what I was reading, and asked me about it (it was a book on scriptural interpretation). This began a 30-minute conversation about Jesus and the faith, something which this young man is interested in learning more about. Like many other young men in his demographic, he is interested in going to church, consumes faith-based content online, and has an affinity for higher-church traditions. When he found out our church has an organ, he asked if our organist has the ability to play anything from Bach (you and I both know the answer to his question is **yes**), he stated he may very well come visit us. Will he? God knows. I don't know, but I am hopeful. For now, what I do have is a few points of reflection:

- **Coffee shops are a great place for a pastor to do work.**
- **There are people in our community ready to engage in faith-based conversations.**
- **God is moving among the next generation.**
- **Join me in prayer for this young man, the next generation, and the community around us as they encounter our Lord, Jesus Christ.**



Youth Group Kick-Off - An immersive devotional journey to start off our year...

The first night of **The Cause** (High School Youth Group) and **Youth Club** (Middle School Bible Study) includes a devotional journey throughout the church. This immersive experience is rooted in our pastoral vision for the ministry year (imitating Christ), and includes the following steps:

- We start in the Welcome Center, where we talk about the importance of **fellowship** and **loving one another**.
- We then move as a group to our baptistry, sit around it (opened), and talk about what **baptism** is and what it means to die to the self and to live in Christ.
- The **Communion** Table is our next stop, where we remember what Christ has done for us.
- Afterward, we head to the Narthex and prayerfully look at the **resurrection** window, and remember how Christ secures our eternal hope in his victory over sin and death.
- Returning into the sanctuary, we gather at the open Bible towards the front of the sanctuary, and recognize **God's word** as His revealed message to us, **illuminated** by the Holy Spirit.
- We trek up to the second floor and into the youth room, where we **pray** to the Lord (using the ACTS acronym).
- Our last stop is in the second floor chapel, where we **silently reflect** on our devotional journey.

Pray for us as we begin our ministry year together through this immersive experience.

Harvest Potluck Gathering & Advent Decoration Night

A celebratory gathering with our church family...

- Join us on the evening of **November 22** for Christmas worship music (led by our high school youth group), a potluck dinner (to celebrate Thanksgiving together), and Advent decorating! **Everyone is invited!** We will also need help! A sign up will be placed in the Welcome Center in mid-October.



90-Day Outlook - Save the dates...

- **Youth Club Kick-Off** - October 7 - Parents Invited!
- **Intergenerational Sunday School Class** - October 11, 9:45am
- **2027 Holy Week Missions Trip Info Meeting** - October 11, 12:00pm (after service)
- **Fall, Fellowship & Fun Event** - October 17 - Youth invited to support!
- **2026 Fall REVIVE Rally** - October 18 - Check LeTourneau's Website for more info!
- **Beaver Camp Fundraiser** - November 7
- **Harvest Gathering & Advent Decorations** - November 22
- **Christmas Mall Trip** - December 19

Upcoming Fellowship Opportunities - Come join us...

- **Canandaigua Connect** (6th-12th grade) - October 8, 6:45am (Tim Horton's, across from Tops)
- **Game Night** - Second Saturday, 6:30pm

ADULT & YOUNG ADULT



Mark's Pastoral Reflection

My journey toward Imitating Jesus...

Many of you know by now that my pastoral vision for this ministry year is **imitating Jesus**. This is a natural outflow of last year's focus, **the Lordship of Jesus**. A spring-time coffee conversation with Jim K. about Thomas Kempis (who wrote a book aptly titled "The Imitation of Christ"), along with a late-summer personal devotional study in Ephesians (Eph. 5:1: "*Therefore be imitators of God, as beloved children*"), ultimately proved influential in my discernment process for the next year's theme. I plan to express this focus through my ministry activities; I hope to become more like Jesus all while inviting others along for the journey.

- **How do I become more like Jesus?** Flanked on both sides of Eph. 5:1 are vice lists. I suspect there is meaning behind this format. Ultimately,

casting our attention onto the model of Jesus exposes the sin around us. In personal reflection, I notice just how apathetic, impatient, and stubbornly independent I am when exposed by the light of Christ. My journey in imitating Christ is the painful, humbling pivot away from those sins.

- **How do I invite others along for the journey?** Those two vice lists meet up with book-ends that echo our baptism (4:22-24 and 5:14). Paul also echoes the eucharist just after his instruction to imitate Jesus (5:2). As a pastor, I aim to invite others along for the journey by pointing others to God and their life within Him; the sacraments (or as us Baptists refer to them: the ordinances) do just that. Moving into the ministry year, I strive to view my pastoral assignment, not with a programmatic lens, but a sacramental one. Will you join me?

Adult Retreat - Pastor Wally Fleming at Onanda Park - A focus on imitating Christ with a United Church favorite guest speaker...

Join us for worship (by Mike O'Brien), lunch, and Pastor Wally Fleming for our next retreat! Bring your own Bible, pen/journal, and anything you need while at a park (Crouch Hall). A free-will donation will be collected at the door during sign-in. A physical sign-up sheet is also in the Welcome Center.

Can you help? We need all sorts of support, including worship planning, sign in, set up/tear down, food shopping/serving, etc.

Agenda

Time | Activity

0930 | Welcome, Prayer & Worship
0945 | Pastor Wally - Session 1
1030 | Break
1045 | Pastor Wally - Session 2
1130 | Break
1145 | Pastor Wally - Closing Remarks
1200 | Prayer & Lunch
1230 | End



New Custodian! - Join us in celebrating our new hire...

Join us in welcoming our new custodian, **Dan C!** He and his wife Doris attend our church. Dan comes to us with valuable custodial experience. We look forward to partnering with and supporting Dan as he onboards. You will also see **Jini H.** in the church conducting special cleaning projects throughout the church. *We are grateful for our gifted and hard-working staff!*

ADULT & YOUNG ADULT



Sunday Morning Small Groups - A time of fellowship, faith discussions, and prayerful study...

We are underway! Join us any time, any week for any of our Sunday morning small groups, listed below. Most of our groups are currently covering the sermon series. Come join us every week, 9:45am-10:45am!

- Parenting Coffee Hour
- All-Adult Small Groups (*we have two of them, with one ending at 10:30am*)
- 25-35 year-old small group
- 18-24 year-old small group
- "What We Believe" Class (runs through November 8)

25-35-Somethings Small Group - An important group in our community that continues to grow...

This growing group continues to meet weekly on Wednesdays, 4:30pm-5:30pm. We are also planning a **Fall gathering** for fellowship and enjoying the seasons changing (more details to be worked out). There is also a **guys night** for this age group planned for October 15 at the church (contact Pastor Mark if interested!) We are currently covering a mix of topics, including:

- Feeling lost or confused in life
- Spiritual forces and realities
- Imitating Christ
- Book-of-the-Bible studies

Pastor Mark's Dissertation Support Team - A multi-year journey of learning and growing together...

This November, I (Mark) am scheduled to submit my dissertation proposal to Northern Seminary. As part of the process, a group of people from in and around the church will walk alongside me as I develop my paper. The exact nature of anyone's involvement will be custom to the interests of those wanting to be involved (anywhere from prayer support, joining me for coffee to chat, to carefully reviewing and handling the text). *Thank you to several of you for reaching out already!* An email is coming later in the Fall with a follow-up. If anyone else has any interest in joining me on this multi-year journey, please let me know!

Mid-Week United Church Groups - Always open to newcomers...

Do you have a group that meets regularly that should get some attention in these lamplighters? Let Pastor Mark know to add your group to the list below! *These and more groups can be found on the church calendar online.*

- Knitters - Tuesdays, 11:00am
- Men's Breakfast - Wednesdays, 7:00am
- 25-35 year-olds Small Group - Wednesdays, 4:30pm
- Women's Bible Study - Thursdays, 1:00pm

Monthly United Church Groups - Join us...

- Ferris Hills - First and Third Wednesday, 1:00pm
- Cheerful Service Circle - Second Monday, 7:00pm
- Circle 7 - Second Tuesday, 11:30am
- Game Night - Second Saturday, 6:30pm
- Prayer Shawl Ministry - Third Tuesday, 7:00pm
- Intergenerational Womens Group - Third Thursday, 5:00pm
- Quail Summit - Fourth Tuesday, 3:00pm

90-Day Outlook - Save the dates...

- **Intergenerational Sunday School Class** - October 11
- **2027 Holy Week Missions Trip Info Meeting** - October 11, 12:00pm (after service)
- **Adult Retreat (w/ Wally Fleming at Onanda Park)** - October 24
- **Exploring Membership Class** - November 15
- **Harvest Gathering & Advent Decorations** - November 22 - More details to come!



Honest Questions

Last month I wrote about what we believe. The Trinity. The person and work of Jesus Christ. The authority of Scripture.

This month, I'd like to move to a more difficult question.

Do our denominations still hold these convictions?

I am not asking this question to worry anyone. But we deserve an honest answer.

Let's start with the PC(USA). The drift hasn't happened all at once. No single vote or meeting. Just a slow redefinition over decades, treating Scripture as a product of its time rather than a Word that still speaks with authority today. The PC(USA) is a connectional church, so decisions made in the General Assembly affect every congregation, whether they agree or not. This has shown up in different ways. Some churches have softened the belief that faith in Christ is necessary for salvation. In some pulpits, people are rallying for political causes instead of teaching the Bible. There is ongoing conversation, too, about the historic Christian understanding of marriage and sexuality.

The Baptist side is no exception, but the drift looks different there, because of how Baptist polity works. Baptists have never allowed denominational offices to hand down instructions. No larger assembly can vote on what a Baptist church believes. Yet the same patterns show up here too. Some congregations increasingly explain away Scripture's commands as outdated rather than treating them as authoritative for us today. Political preaching sometimes takes the place of biblical teaching. Questions surface about the historic view of marriage and sexuality. They just show up quietly, congregation by congregation, region by region, rather than through any single denominational decision. Some ABCUSA churches hold firmly to the Gospel. Others have moved considerably away from it.

So what does this mean for us? We are both Baptist and Presbyterian, and ultimately a United Church. The reality is that no meeting, no assembly, no denominational trend can make decisions for The United Church. This is freedom. Yet it is not a guarantee that we will remain faithful.

This is why TFC (The Fellowship Community) has been so helpful for us. It exists because many Gospel-centered churches inside the PC(USA), churches like ours, saw these dynamics and chose to stay in the denomination rather than walk away. And TFC helps us hold to our essential beliefs, rather than bend to cultural trends. We are not alone. We are one congregation among many.

So yes. The shifting is real, in both of our traditions. We can't pretend this isn't true. But to be fair, neither denomination has abandoned the faith outright. We are not sounding an alarm. We are not leaving. We are not panicking. We already know what we believe. That is exactly what lets us look at our denominational homes honestly, without fear.

Next month, let's talk about why we're still here.

Wade

This article is part of an ongoing series on The United Church and our denominational connections, including The Fellowship Community. Past installments are posted at uccdga.org/tfc.



THE
**UNITED
CHURCH**
CANANDAIGUA

The United Church
Presbyterian-American Baptist
11 Gibson Street
Canandaigua, NY 14424

Non-Profit Org.
Postage Paid
Permit No. 26
Canandaigua, NY 14424

Or Current Resident